

PRODUCT MESSAGING GUIDE

Template & Annotated Example

A reusable framework for building a single source of messaging truth

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GUIDANCE This is an illustrative template built around a fictional product, Northwind Lumen™ from the fictional Northwind Technologies. It serves two purposes: to demonstrate how I structure product messaging, and to set the standard I expect from a product marketing team. Blue GUIDANCE boxes explain the intent of each section and what “good” looks like; the EXAMPLE text under each shows the standard applied. All market data is illustrative and should be replaced with current, sourced figures before use.

How to Use This Guide

A product messaging guide is the single source of truth for how a product is described everywhere it appears in campaigns, sales decks, the website, analyst briefings, partner content, and third-party media. It is not a campaign and not a brochure. It is the upstream document every downstream asset inherits from.

GUIDANCE The value of this document is consistency and reuse. When it is done well, anyone, in any region, on any team, or at any agency, can lift a section and drop it into an asset knowing the message is on-brand, accurate, and approved. If two sellers in two geographies describe the product differently, this document has failed. Complete it early, keep it versioned, and treat it as governed content, not a draft.

1. Document Control & Purpose

GUIDANCE Open every messaging guide by declaring who it's for, what it's for, when it's created in the process, and the outcome it drives. This frames the document as a system component, not a one-off. Keep it to four crisp lines.

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Audience: Corporate, Integrated, Field & Partner Marketing; Sales Enablement; approved agencies.

Intent: The source platform for all internal and external communications about this product. Sections are meant to be extracted and reused across collateral, campaigns, and the buyer's journey.

Stage in process: Completed second, after the market/opportunity brief. Establishes the standardized messaging all other assets inherit.

Objective: Ensure that wherever and however the product is discussed, the message is consistent across teams, regions, and partners.

2. Product / Solution Details

GUIDANCE Capture the facts that downstream teams need but shouldn't have to chase: names, key dates, and the launch moment the messaging attaches to. Fill every field or mark it TBD with an owner.

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Product name: Northwind Lumen™

Internal code name: Project Beacon

Category: AI-powered data intelligence & enterprise search platform

General availability: [Date]

Marketing launch date / moment: [Date] — anchored to the Northwind AI Summit keynote

3. Ownership & Contacts

GUIDANCE Name the humans. A messaging guide with no owners becomes stale and unaccountable. List the DRI for the message and everyone who must approve a change.

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Product Marketing owner (DRI): [Name]

Product Management: [Name]

Corporate Communications: [Name]

Approved agency / media firm: [Name]

Regional ambassadors & technical evangelists: [Names by geo]

4. Market Overview

GUIDANCE Ground the product in a market the buyer already believes is real, using current, sourced third-party data. This is where credibility is won or lost; never invent numbers, always cite, and replace figures as they age. The point is not to describe the market exhaustively, but to establish the shift that makes this product matter now.

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Market context

Enterprises are investing heavily in AI, but most of that value is gated by a data problem: models and agents are only as good as the trusted, governed data they can reach. The enterprise search and data-intelligence category are being redefined as the layer that makes enterprise data findable and usable by both people and AI. [Insert current, sourced market size and CAGR here as an illustrative placeholder.]

Market drivers

- Generative and agentic AI create urgent demand for governed, retrieval-ready enterprise data (RAG, tool access).
- “Dark data” (the unstructured, forgotten content most organizations can’t see) keeps growing across siloed repositories and clouds.
- Governance, privacy, and permission-awareness are now buying criteria, not afterthoughts.
- Buyers increasingly evaluate whether a platform is open and API-first so AI systems can consume it.

Planning assumptions (illustrative)

- A growing share of enterprise “searches” will be natural-language questions from people and agents rather than keyword queries.
- The best answer to a business question will increasingly assemble multiple content types (documents, data, audio, video, machine-generated signals) not a single file.

5. Why This Product Matters

GUIDANCE Use the Why / How / What structure (belief → approach → product). Lead with the belief, because buyers connect to purpose before features. The product should be the last thing you name, not the first.

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Why: We believe every organization should be able to make all its data available, trustworthy, and actionable to people and to the AI working alongside them.

How: That is only possible from a governed, centralized intelligence layer that serves the organization’s information supply chain, making data easier to find, understand, share, and act on without moving or duplicating it.

What: Northwind Lumen aggregates disparate repositories into an indexed, permission-aware data fabric. Through it, authorized people and AI agents can explore, analyze, and act on information in natural language, regardless of where the data lives or what format it's in.

6. Positioning Statement

GUIDANCE *The positioning statement is the spine every other section hangs from. Use the disciplined form: For [target] who [need], [product] is a [category] that [key benefit]. Unlike [alternative], it [differentiator]. It is an internal alignment tool (precise over pretty) not ad copy.*

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

For enterprises whose people and AI systems struggle to find trusted information scattered across siloed repositories, Northwind Lumen is an AI-powered data intelligence platform that unifies structured and unstructured data into a governed, searchable fabric, surfacing accurate, permission-aware answers in natural language. Unlike bolt-on search tools or single-repository connectors, Lumen pairs enterprise-grade governance with agent-ready APIs, so both people and AI reach for the right data by default.

7. Core Value Statement

GUIDANCE *One or two sentences that scale the positioning up to its fullest promise. This is the line an executive should be able to repeat after hearing it once.*

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Northwind Lumen is the most flexible, governed platform for turning an organization's scattered data into trusted answers for every knowledge worker and every AI agent. It meets the enterprise's need for control and compliance and the user's need for a simple, self-service, natural-language experience, without forcing a trade-off between the two.

8. Elevator Pitches

GUIDANCE *Provide tiered pitches for different moments and listeners. The primary is the full, credible story; the secondary answers "what do you do?" conversationally; the tertiary is a longer, curiosity-driven version for a warm audience. Each should stand on its own and stay in the buyer's language, not the org chart's.*

Primary

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

How do organizations help their people, and now their AI, quickly find the right information across formats, locations, and repositories? Studies consistently show knowledge workers lose a large share of their day just gathering, converting, or recreating information that already exists. We believe every bit of an organization's data should be available, trustworthy, and actionable. Northwind Lumen creates a centralized, governed intelligence layer that is a single place for people and agents to explore, analyze, and understand data relevant to a business problem. Big, deep, or dark, wherever it lives: only when the useful information surfaces can you decide with confidence.

Secondary

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

"What do you do?" We make sure people don't get lost in all the data their company has. We give them, and their AI tools, a simple way to reach the relevant, accurate data they need, in a usable form, at the moment they need it, without compromising the organization's security and governance policies.

Tertiary

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Everyone knows data is growing faster than anyone can keep up with, not just big, but deep, and often dark when it's forgotten. That means your people and your AI have more places to look and more time lost looking. Northwind Lumen aggregates your repositories into one governed, indexed fabric so exploration focuses on the data with the highest value to the business. Organizations using it recover meaningful productivity simply by cutting the time spent hunting for what already exists. Whether it's a fit depends on how much data you have, how many silos, and how often your team recreates work they couldn't find. I'd be glad to talk through it.

9. Narrative

GUIDANCE *The narrative is the long-form story that campaigns and briefings draw from. Structure it as the opportunity (the market truth and customer constraint) followed by what we're announcing (the product as the answer). Keep the opportunity customer-owned before the product ever enters.*

The opportunity

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Organizations place ever-greater value on their data, yet only a few can truly make sense of the volume they own, share, and are affected by, arriving at bewildering speed and in every format, on top of vast forgotten "dark data." Knowledge workers rarely have the tools to explore even the data they know about, let alone what they don't. The result is duplicated work, slower decisions, greater risk, and endless infrastructure spend to keep pace with growth. Now AI raises the stakes: models and agents are only as trustworthy as the governed data they can reach.

What we're announcing

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Northwind Lumen, an extensible enterprise search and data-intelligence platform that integrates disparate repositories through a rule-based central index and exposes them to people and AI alike. It is optimized for performance and scale, real-time connection of heterogeneous repositories, self-service exploration by end users and agents, and the governance and workflow controls IT and information architects require. Lumen deploys flexibly, on dedicated hardware, as a virtual machine, as a container, or as a cloud-hosted service. The bottom line: enterprises get real-time analytics, indexing, search, and visualization that expose insight for faster decisions, higher productivity, and reduced risk.

10. Tagline Options

GUIDANCE *Offer a small set of on-strategy options, each with a headline and a clarifying sub-headline. Taglines should ladder up to the positioning, never freelance a clever line that the rest of the guide can't support.*

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

- **Be in the Know.** Surface accurate, relevant answers from big, deep, and dark data including what you didn't know you had.
- **Find the Why Behind the What.** Move from keyword search to AI-guided discovery across human and machine data.
- **Connect. Understand. Act.** One governed platform for intelligent access, exploration, and analysis of all your organizational information.

11. Count-Limited Copy Blocks

GUIDANCE Pre-write approved descriptions at fixed lengths so downstream teams never have to improvise (or mis-describe) the product to fit a space. Provide 25-, 50-, and 100-word versions at minimum. This is one of the highest-leverage, most-reused sections of the guide.

25 words

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Northwind Lumen delivers AI-powered search, real-time analytics, and automated indexing across structured and unstructured data so people and agents surface trusted, actionable answers fast.

50 words

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Northwind Lumen is an extensible data-intelligence platform for exploring structured and unstructured enterprise data. It aggregates disparate repositories and correlates internal and external streams so trusted, permission-aware insights surface efficiently for knowledge workers and AI agents alike. Lumen is enterprise-ready, governed, and genuinely self-service.

100 words

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Northwind Lumen is an extensible platform that combines data exploration with content analytics to enable comprehensive data mapping, guided discovery, and actionable insight. For the first time, organizations have a governed, enterprise-managed intelligence layer that improves productivity through a dynamic, adaptive approach to how data is located, understood, and used by people and by AI. Lumen centralizes and standardizes how human- and machine-generated content is explored, shifting the organization's focus away from where content lives and who can reach it, toward how it is correlated and visualized to deliver value, all within the enterprise's security and governance policies.

12. Key Customer Benefits

GUIDANCE State benefits as outcomes the buyer cares about, each with a short proof of how the product delivers it. Lead with the outcome, not the feature — the feature is evidence.

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

- **Trusted answers for people and AI.** A governed, permission-aware layer feeds retrieval-ready data to knowledge workers and AI agents, so the right answer surfaces regardless of format or location.
- **Holistic, data-driven decisions.** Aggregating structured, semi-structured, and unstructured data builds a 360° view of the business that improves operational effectiveness.
- **Guided discovery.** Automatic classification and visualization expose trends, patterns, and relationships across internal and external sources.
- **Lower risk and cost.** Self-service, secure search reduces duplicated work, shrinks reliance on scarce IT resources, and limits exposure of sensitive data.

13. Top Reasons to Buy

GUIDANCE For each headline reason, give three layers: how the customer is affected (the problem in their words), the business message (value for the economic buyer), and the technical message (credibility for the evaluator). This lets one entry serve both the CIO brief and the practitioner one-pager.

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

Improve data quality and knowledge extraction — automatically

How the customer is affected: New content arrives at breakneck speed in countless formats, on top of mountains of legacy data. The challenge is making it work in the organization's favor rather than drowning in it.

- **Business message:** Lumen automates the extraction, classification, enrichment, and categorization of data across first-party and third-party sources, on-premises and in cloud, cutting the time wasted searching for, or recreating, what already exists.
- **Technical message:** A modular connector service and visual workflow designer connect heterogeneous sources (object storage, NAS, S3, data-integration pipelines) quickly, so data awareness scales with data growth; no point solutions required.

Reduce legal and compliance risk

How the customer is affected: Compliance teams must locate and access dispersed data for early case assessment and investigations — often depending on IT and risking exposure of sensitive content.

- **Business message:** Lumen supports governance and compliance discovery, legal hold, records retention, early case assessment with secure, self-service natural-language search across on-prem, hybrid, and public-cloud repositories.
- **Technical message:** Strict authentication and access controls (Active Directory, LDAP) ensure only authorized users reach sensitive data, while the extensible framework tailors the experience per role.

14. Messaging Standards & Governance

GUIDANCE Close the guide with the standards the team is held to. This section is where a PMM leader sets expectations — it turns a document into a discipline.

EXAMPLE — Northwind Lumen™

- **Single source of truth.** All external and internal copy about this product derives from this guide. If it isn't here, it isn't approved.
- **Evidence over adjectives.** Every claim is backed by a source, a proof point, or a customer outcome. No superlatives we can't defend to an analyst.
- **Outcomes before features.** Lead with what the buyer achieves; use the feature as the reason to believe.
- **Audience-tiered and modular.** Maintain business and technical versions, and fixed-length blocks, so any team can reuse without rewriting.
- **Consistent globally.** Regional teams localize tone and examples, never the core positioning or claims.
- **Versioned and governed.** Every change is versioned, dated, and approved by the named owners. Review at each launch and quarterly.

Illustrative sample authored by Scott Baker. Northwind Technologies and Northwind Lumen are fictional; all market data is illustrative and shown to demonstrate structure and standards.